How to Write Interview Questions

Identify the focus of your interview

- Who is invested in the topic?
  - What perspectives are not yet covered in your research?
  - What makes someone an expert?
- What is being done locally about your topic?
  - City initiatives
  - Clubs, organizations, and nonprofits
  - Research

How to Write Interview Questions

Brainstorm things you want to know about that topic:

- What got them involved in the topic?
- What challenges did they face?
- What changes are happening, good or bad?
- What misconceptions do they want to clear up?

How to Write Interview Questions

Ask varied questions, but keep them open-ended

- Try not to ask “yes” or “no” questions
- OR write some potential follow-up questions depending on “yes” or “no”
- Ask them to tell you a story
- Ask them to define terms or explain complex ideas

How to Write Interview Questions

Try to ask at least one question from each category:

- Descriptive (“What’s happening?”)
- Interpretive (“Why is it happening?”)
- Reflective (“How do you think it could change?”)

Asking to observe a gathering...

Hello [Name],

I am writing a research paper for a class at Iowa State University over [topic] and I would love the opportunity to observe [organization, committee, etc.] during one of your meetings.

If possible, I would love to record the meeting for accurate note-taking. However, if this is not possible, I would be happy to just take notes based on what I've observed.

Please let me know if I would be able to sit in on a meeting and, if so, when the best time to meet would be. Thank you for your time!

Best,

[Your name]

How to Prepare for Observations

- Create a system for note-taking *even if you're recording*
- Make a list of questions you hope to answer through the observation
  - Ex. "What do they see as most important?"
  - Ex. "What initiatives are they working on right now?"
- Observe reactions, tone, handouts, etc. as well as what's directly stated
  - Just make sure it's clear this is your perception of what happened in the notes

For both interviews and observations...

- Don’t be afraid to email with follow-up questions or clarifications
- Make sure you email one last time when you’re done, thanking them for their time
  - *Optional: Send them your final paper in the thank you email so they can see where they fit into the project*
- Only cite direct quotes if you’re confident they’re accurate, otherwise paraphrase (still needs a parenthetical)

Citing Interviews and Observations

Interview:

Smith, Jane. Personal interview. 19 May 2024.

[Name of person being interviewed]. Personal interview. [Date interview was conducted].

* The date should be the date of their response, if completed asynchronously

Observation:

Graduate and Professional Student Senate. *August Meeting*. Observed by Wren Bouwman on 3 October 2025, Iowa State University.

[Name of organization]. [Title of meeting]. Observed by [your name] on [date observed], [location].

Questions to ask for each source:

Does this present a new perspectives, enhance a perspective in another article, or repeat information?

Who is the audience? Experts? Laypersons?

What quotes provide especially strong evidence, either though research, statistics, or personal experiences?

Learning Activity:

1. a list of at least 3 sources in MLA format
2. Describe the different perspectives in 2-3 sentences each
3. One idea for your interview or observation
4. Three possible research questions for that source